over those exams has not lifted.

The high-octane Jharkhand youth agitation of August had a cluster of demands related to the tainted recruitment process, but one of them was non-negotiatiable for the protesters: the cancellation of all exams put into doubt by the state's long history sheet of paper leaks. When the Hemant Soren government finally gave in to the pressure, 22 recruitment exams stood annulled, six fresh exam timelines were on hold and 17 older ones brought within the scope of investigation. The cancelled list included the 11th to 13th JPSC Combined Civil Services examinations, the Food Safety Officer recruitment, the CDPO examination and the JSSC-CGL examination.

The JSSC-CGL timeline illustrates the abnormality most sharply. Its 2023 edition was reheld in September 2024, after the first one was cancelled following a paper leak controversy. The second one, too, attracted allegations of malpractice. But in December 2025, the court lifted the freeze on its result—after the state said a CID probe had found no evidence of a paper leak. Appointment letters were distributed on December 30, 2025. The euphoria has lasted less than eight months.

Do they have a job? Well, they do possess a legal argument. The high court's view is that the fair and regular appointments within the larger set could not simply be treated as collateral damage and not segregating them would violate natural justice. But it's provisional: the court has not declared the examinations clean. The investigation is ongoing. With the Jharkhand Public Service Commission still to be reconstituted after the high-profile arrest of its chairman, the fate of the nine pending exams, including the state civil services mains, continue to be in a limbo too.

Out in the secretariat, meanwhile, the recruitment logjam is pushing departments towards contractual hiring. The whole thing could become a Murphy's Law case study at an officers' training academy—provided you get there through fair means. ■

**Takeaways**

- **When Soren regime annulled 22 exams, nearly 2,000 new state govt recruits find job in peril**
- **HC stays the blanket layoff, says segregation must be done of those who passed fairly**
- **Cancelling these exams was a key demand of youth protests. Cloud lingers still, probe on**

## WHEAT WITH CHAFF

It was a desperate attempt to restore confidence, but there was a catch. The exams had produced employees. Young people had made life decisions, taken up jobs, settled—the very destination they sought in years of enduring the grind and succeeding in intensely competitive exams. They certainly could not be collectively tarnished—there was no way of knowing who among them had profited unfairly. Indeed, many would have succeeded in a field where others were cheating! But now jeopardy was visited upon them equally. Some had taken their jobs only after the court allowed things to move forward.

*By* **Rohit Parihar**

**After the results streamed in on September 14,** Prime Minister Narendra Modi duly congratulated the winning candidates and the "entire BJP family". After all, the broad reading it gave of the political mood in Rajasthan's cities and towns was net net positive. These civic elections were the first time the party was being tested after it came to power in December 2023, and it had endured. Yet, a bit of needle hung in the air. Modi spoke of defeating "echoes of lies". What explained the attritional aftertaste?

Because the numbers were lower than ideal, though better than many expected. It's a delicate cusp when modesty ('it could have been better') is outweighed by relief ('it could have been worse'). These were strictly urban body polls, covering 14.4 million voters, only one-fourth of the state's electorate of 51.5 million and a traditionally pro-BJP bloc. Read the big numbers in that light: the BJP won 4,179 wards; rival Congress got 3,613; Independents/Others took 2,449. Of the 309 civic bodies at stake, the BJP won 85 against Congress's 45, the rest were hung.



**OVER THE HILL** Voters in line for the urban body polls, Jaipur, Sept. 11